

500 Registrations in 7 Days — a Referral Growth Engine

Workshop: **Build Your First AI Project in 60 Minutes** (free, live) · Live asset: [nxtwave-ai-launchpad.vercel.app](#)

500 STUDENTS TO REGISTER	₹2,000 TOTAL BUDGET	7 days CAMPAIGN WINDOW	1 PRODUCT, SHIPPED LIVE
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1. Understand the student

Who exactly: Final-year B.Tech / B.E. students (CSE, IT, ECE & allied) in Tier-2/Tier-3 colleges, 3–8 months from placements, with a thin GitHub and a vague "I should learn AI" anxiety.

Why they care: Placement season is here and their resume has coursework, not proof. "Everyone is doing AI." They don't need another 10-hour course they'll abandon — they need **one finished, demoable thing, fast**.

What makes them register: (1) low time cost — 60 min, not a semester; (2) a tangible outcome — a real AI app on GitHub + a live link for the resume *today*; (3) social proof + FOMO — friends are joining, seats are limited; (4) zero price, zero risk.

Core insight that shaped everything: a final-year student's scarcest resource isn't money — it's **believable, finishable proof of skill before placements**. The offer and the asset both sell exactly that.

2. The campaign — 1 engine + 3 channels (prioritised, not 20 ideas)

The engine: a referral growth loop. ₹2,000 can't *buy* 500 registrations — it can only *seed* a few hundred and let students bring the rest. So every registrant becomes a channel: register → personal code → 1-tap WhatsApp invite → leaderboard + reward tiers. *(This is the asset I built.)*

Channel 1 — WhatsApp (primary engine). ~60%. Seed the page into final-year class/placement groups via 15–20 student "campus leads." Each registrant gets a code + pre-written invite. *Why:* it's where this audience already coordinates placements — trust + reach built in, loop compounds inside the groups at zero CAC.

Channel 2 — College coding clubs (GDSC, CodeChef, IEEE). ~25%. DM 10–12 club leads a ready-to-post bundle + their club's own tracked link. *Why:* one message = hundreds of relevant students, delivered by a trusted source.

Channel 3 — tiny Instagram seed. ~15%. ₹1,600 on a sharp Reel targeting final-year CS students — only to ignite the first ~150 registrants, who then refer. *Why:* paid is the spark, not the plan.

Deliberately cut: generic email blasts, LinkedIn cold outreach, 20-influencer deals, SEO content — too slow or too costly for a 7-day / ₹2,000 box.

BUDGET LINE	₹	DAY	LEVER	CUMULATIVE
Instagram seed ads	1,600	1–2	IG seed + WhatsApp seeding	150
Referral reward fulfilment	400	3–4	Referral loop + club posts	330
Landing page / tools (built with AI, hosted free)	0	5–6	Leaderboard race + tiers	460
Total	2,000	7	"Seats almost full" push	520

How the 500 come in: if ~170 engaged registrants each bring just **2 friends**, that's 340 referred + 170 = **510 registrations** — hit almost entirely through earned reach. The product is engineered to make referring the path of least resistance.

3. The one thing I built

A **gamified referral growth engine** — landing page + referral code/tracker + engagement tooling in one product. Register → auto-generated code → WhatsApp share → live leaderboard → reward tiers → a 0→500 goal bar. It *is* Channel 1's engine, not a brochure for it. **Live & interactive:** [nxtwave-ai-launchpad.vercel.app](#) · Code: [github.com/rakshann05/ai-launchpad](#)

4. How I thought

What changed between first idea and final solution? My first idea was a polished landing page with a form. I rejected it — a landing page is a dead end; it can't manufacture reach and ₹2,000 can't buy 500 signups. The final solution makes

every registrant a distribution channel via a referral loop with visible status and rewards. The asset went from "a page that collects" to "a machine that spreads."

If I had another 24 hours? Wire a real backend (Supabase) so referrals attribute across users and the leaderboard is genuinely live; add an admin dashboard with per-channel/*ref* conversion so spend can be reallocated daily; A/B test two hero messages and two reward structures to find the highest viral coefficient.

What did AI suggest that I rejected, and why? AI pushed maximising channels (email + LinkedIn + Discord + SEO + 20 influencers) and spending the whole ₹2,000 on ads. I rejected both — spreading thin kills the loop's compounding, and ads buy a spike, not a loop. I also rejected cash rewards (wrong, extrinsic crowd + burns budget) for status/career rewards that cost ~₹0.